PRACTICAL WORKPLACE PSYCHOLOGY

Understanding Workplace Stress

How survival biology, cognition and workplace conditions shape stress and recovery

Stress involves the brain, the body and the meaning a person gives to what is happening. It tends to rise when a situation feels threatening or when the demands appear greater than the resources available. A short burst can sharpen action. Repeated activation, especially with little control, support or recovery, narrows attention, reduces flexibility and makes protective habits harder to change.

Why this matters at work

Employers rely on people who can think clearly, adapt, collaborate and learn under uncertainty. Employees do their best work when expectations are manageable, their contribution has meaning, they can speak openly and they have time to recover. Healthy working conditions support both wellbeing and dependable performance.

Workshop learning objectives

By the end of the workshop, participants will be able to understand how biology, cognition and working conditions interact in stress; recognise stress and avoidance patterns at work; and identify practical individual and organisational responses.

What employees need	What organisations need
Clear priorities and realistic expectations	Reliable decisions and consistent execution
Influence over how work is done	Adaptability without chronic overload
Respect, belonging and permission to speak up	Learning, collaboration and early risk reporting
Recovery, support and fair treatment	Retention, engagement and healthy performance

Resilience grows when people and organisations can respond to pressure, recover afterwards and learn from the experience.

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THE SURVIVAL SYSTEM

An ancient alarm in a modern workplace

Primate survival depends on detecting predators and navigating social life. Rank, uncertainty, exclusion, conflict, access to resources and the availability of allies can all affect stress physiology. The workplace has its own versions of these pressures. Status instability, low control and weak social support can carry biological weight even when physical safety is assured.

Humans respond through the same broad protective architecture. The brain evaluates what matters, the autonomic nervous system adjusts arousal and the hypothalamic–pituitary–adrenal axis mobilises energy through cortisol. Cortisol is a steroid hormone with an essential role in adaptation. Difficulties arise when activation continues for too long or the body has too little opportunity to recover.

A simple neuroscience map

1 Detect The amygdala contributes to detecting emotionally significant information. The hippocampus supplies memory and context, helping distinguish “this resembles a past threat” from “this is safe now”.

2 Mobilise The hypothalamus coordinates autonomic and endocrine responses. Sympathetic activation prepares the body for rapid action. The HPA axis follows with a slower hormonal response.

3 Prioritise The anterior insula and anterior cingulate are involved in salience, bodily awareness, attention and monitoring conflict. Attention shifts toward what seems urgent.

4 Regulate Prefrontal networks support working memory, inhibition, planning, perspective and flexible decisions. Under high stress, these executive functions can become less efficient while faster, habitual responses gain influence.

5 Recover Parasympathetic processes help the body settle. This recovery phase restores cognitive and physiological capacity and prepares the person for the next period of effort.

What the alarm reads as threat today

A public attack in a meeting, an ambiguous message from a manager, shifting priorities, impossible deadlines, constant interruption, job insecurity, exclusion, ethical conflict or having no influence over one’s work can all be appraised as threats. The response is real even when the stimulus is symbolic or social.

Stress emerges through interacting brain networks, bodily systems, past learning and the current social environment.

The avoidance cycle at work

Appraisal shapes the response

The transactional model begins with two appraisals. A person considers whether the situation represents a threat, loss, challenge or something irrelevant. They then consider the resources available to deal with it. Stress rises when perceived demands exceed perceived capacity. The same deadline may energise one person and overwhelm another because each person evaluates the demand and their resources differently.

Attention and thinking narrow under strain

Stress draws attention towards possible threat and leaves less capacity for the wider context. Working memory and cognitive flexibility may suffer. People can miss nuance, fall back on familiar responses, catastrophise, search for confirming negative evidence or underestimate their ability to cope. Worry anticipates danger, while rumination replays earlier events. Each can keep the alarm active while producing little useful action.

Avoidance is negatively reinforced

Avoidance often brings immediate relief. Skipping a difficult conversation, delaying a task or staying silent lowers discomfort, and the brain learns from that result. Psychologists call this negative reinforcement: removing an unpleasant feeling strengthens the behaviour that removed it. Repetition limits the chance to discover that the situation may be manageable, that anxiety can settle during the experience or that support is available.

Workplace pattern	Immediate payoff	Longer-term cost
Avoiding feedback or conflict	Relief from tension	Problems remain and conversations feel more threatening
Over-checking and perfectionism	Temporary certainty	Slower work, fatigue and reduced trust
Saying yes to every request	Avoids disapproval	Overload, resentment and lower-quality delivery
Manager avoids naming overload	Avoids an uncomfortable trade-off	The system learns that hidden overwork is normal

What helps break the loop

Start with an action that feels manageable. Clarify the actual risk, separate facts from predictions, identify one controllable step, practise the difficult behaviour gradually and review what happened. With repetition, effective action and new learning can become sources of relief.

Workshop exercise | A difficult conversation

A manager postpones a conversation with an overloaded employee because it feels uncomfortable. In pairs, identify the immediate relief, the longer-term consequences, and one proportionate next step. What would need to change in the work environment?

Some avoidance protects people from genuine harm. Leaving danger, stopping harassment and declining unsafe work are appropriate responses. A useful test is to ask whether the action reduces a real risk or only eases anxiety while the original problem continues to grow.

WORKPLACE APPLICATION

Design work for sustainable performance

Breathing, exercise, sleep, mindfulness and cognitive reframing can improve regulation. Their effect is limited when people face unmanageable workloads, contradictory priorities, unfairness or unsafe leadership every day. Current workplace guidance gives organisations responsibility for preventing psychosocial risks, with trained managers and practical individual tools forming part of the wider response.

Lever	What good practice looks like	A useful question
Demand	Priorities, staffing and deadlines are realistic. Overload triggers trade-offs	What will stop, move or receive more resources?
Control	People have meaningful influence over methods, pace and sequencing	Where can this person make the decision?
Clarity	Roles, standards and decision rights are explicit	What does good enough look like here?
Safety	People can raise questions, mistakes and concerns without humiliation	Which concerns reach us too late?
Support	Managers notice changes, listen, respond and know escalation routes	What support would make this workable?
Recovery	Breaks, boundaries and post-peak decompression are protected	Where is recovery built into the plan?
Fairness	Work allocation, recognition and change processes are explainable	Can we explain this decision consistently?

A practical response when pressure rises

1 Stabilise Reduce immediate arousal: pause, slow the breathing pattern, move, hydrate or create a short break from stimulation.

2 Name Describe the trigger, the interpretation and the bodily or behavioural response without judgement.

3 Test Ask what is known, what is predicted, how likely the feared outcome is and what resources are available.

4 Act Choose one proportionate action: clarify, prioritise, ask for support, set a boundary, rehearse or approach gradually.

5 Learn Review the outcome and adjust the work system as well as the individual response.

Persistent distress, marked impairment or any risk of harm requires support from qualified clinical or emergency services. This guide is intended for workplace education and prevention.

Reviewing stress in your team

Use these questions in a team review

- ✓ Which recurring situations trigger the strongest threat response in our work?
- ✓ Where do people lack clarity, influence, resources or permission to challenge?
- ✓ Which avoidance patterns bring short-term relief and later create delay, silence or rework?
- ✓ Which manager behaviours lower uncertainty and which unintentionally amplify it?
- ✓ How will we know whether an intervention improves health and performance?

What to measure

Combine brief employee feedback with operational indicators. Useful measures include perceived workload, control, role clarity, psychological safety, recovery, support and fairness alongside absence, turnover, errors, rework, incidents and missed deadlines. Look for patterns by team or work process, protect confidentiality and use the findings to improve working conditions.

Closing reflection | From insight to action

Identify one stress pattern you recognise, one factor you or your team can influence, and one practical change worth discussing or testing. Agree how you will review what happens.

How I can help

I translate psychology and neuroscience into practical workplace action. Through tailored workshops, stress and wellbeing education, team sessions and organisational consultation, I help leaders, managers and employees understand what drives pressure and decide where change is possible. The work focuses on reducing avoidable harm, strengthening useful coping skills and building conditions that support healthy performance.

Discuss a workshop or consultation **george@gbcwellbeing.com / 079 859 38 88**

Selected evidence and guidance

World Health Organization (2022), Guidelines on mental health at work. World Economic Forum (2025), Future of Jobs Report 2025. Swiss State Secretariat for Economic Affairs, Psychosocial risks at work. Health Promotion Switzerland (2022), Job Stress Index 2022. ISO 45003:2021, Psychological health and safety at work. Lazarus & Folkman (1984), Stress, Appraisal, and Coping. Sapolsky (2005), The influence of social hierarchy on primate health. Science, 308, 648–652. Shields, Sazma & Yonelinas (2016), The effects of acute stress on core executive functions. Neuroscience & Biobehavioral Reviews, 68, 651–668. Hofmann & Hay (2018), Rethinking avoidance. Journal of Anxiety Disorders, 55, 14–21.

This guide brings together George's teaching materials on stress, anxiety and suffering with current workplace guidance. It supports education and prevention. Qualified health professionals remain responsible for clinical diagnosis and treatment.